

Strong bond: According to Dravid, mentorship and trust define Sanju Samson's relationship with the Rajasthan Royals squad, which is evident in their mutual respect.

RITU RAJ KONWAR

experience both sides of this journey.

In some ways, it's like raising children. When they're young, your conversations with them are different, but as they mature, those interactions evolve. It's no different with players.

You have to adapt to who you are coaching and focus on the goal you're trying to achieve.

You compared nurturing young cricketers to raising children. As a parent to two young cricketers, has that experience helped you understand the psyche of budding players better?

Working with junior cricket at the NCA and the Under-19 level has definitely helped me connect better with young players.

Every cricketer is different. At one time, there was Riyan Parag, Sanju, and Yashasvi Jaiswal, and now we have youngsters like Vaibhav Suryavanshi. The players keep changing, but my experience at the NCA and with U-19 cricket has been invaluable.

I've really enjoyed that side of coaching — it has taught me a lot as well.

You've seen Sanju grow from his early days. What are your thoughts on his leadership at RR?

Sanju has grown significantly as both a cricketer and a captain. Captaincy is a skill where the more you do it, the better you become. It's about gaining experience and learning from different situations.

What stands out about Sanju is his curiosity and willingness to learn. He is always asking questions, eager to improve, and has really embraced his leadership role. There is great clarity in how he communicates with the group. He knows exactly what he wants from the team and what he



aims to achieve.

I've told him that our job as coaches is to support his vision. That's how I see coaching — it's about helping the captain and his team create an environment where they can play the brand of cricket they want to. While the captain drives the vision, we are there to support, guide, and facilitate it.

Sanju leads by example and has a strong connection with the younger players. He has seen many of them grow within the franchise and played a role in their development. That mutual respect and trust between him and the squad is evident.

There's a great synergy within the team, which Sanju has fostered well. His experience and performances over the years have earned him respect, not just from the younger players but also from the overseas professionals. Beyond that, he genuinely cares about his teammates, and that balance of respect, care, and leadership makes him an effective captain.

What are your thoughts on the Impact Player rule in the IPL? How much has it changed the nature of



Rahul Dravid in IPL

Rajasthan Royals' new head coach for a multi-year term ahead of IPL 2025

RR team mentor in 2014 and 2015 (team reached the playoffs) Delhi Daredevils (now Delhi Capitals) team mentor in 2016 and 2017 – DD finished sixth in both seasons

the tournament?

It has certainly added a different dynamic. I'll be honest: when I was India's coach, I wasn't particularly fond of the Impact Player rule.

Not because it doesn't make the game more competitive — it certainly does. It adds complexity and keeps matches alive till the very end. But from a national team perspective, it posed some challenges. As a coach, you want to develop all-rounders, and under the old 11 vs 11 format, certain players would have had more opportunities to bat or bowl in different situations.

The Impact Player rule has changed that to some extent. That